

**THE ROLE OF RELIGIOUS DIALOGUE IN A PEACEFUL LIFE OF FOLLOWERS OF  
RELIGION**

**THE ROLE OF RELIGION IN PEACEFUL COEXISTENCE**

**THE FIRST INTERNATIONAL CONFERENCE ON IMAM REZA AND INTERFAITH  
DIALOGUE**

**TEHERAN**

**ISLAMIC REPUBLIC OF IRAN**

**PREPARED: BY REV. CANON. THOMAS GODDA MUYYA**

**ANGLICAN PASTOR AND**

**EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR INTERRELIGIOUS COUNCIL FOR PEACE TANZANIA (*RfP*)**

**Contacts:** P.O. Box 5324 Dar es Salaam, Tanzania

**Cell phone//What's App:** +255 717 013 404

**Email.** [goddamuyya@yahoo.com](mailto:goddamuyya@yahoo.com); [vicent1951@gmail.com](mailto:vicent1951@gmail.com)

**THE ROLE OF INTERFAITH DIALOGUE IN PEACEFUL COEXISTENCE**

**INTRODUCTION**

Interfaith relation is a culture where different religious communities live in harmony without prejudice against the other. It is a continuous practical interaction through voluntary and free

constructive dialogue. It involves building trust and respect among people of faith; accepting each other as equal human beings of this globe; equal citizens, brothers and sisters.

Religious Dialogue is a dialogue of discourse between people of different religions, recognizing their common origin as God's creation a property He loves and cares. Dialogue is a voluntary act of people who have different cultures, have different religions, faiths, or different ethnicity; stretching hands of friendship, in order to coexist peacefully and harmony.

It is a voluntary act of coming out of our religious walls/boundaries, and sit in a round table to discuss constructively in order to come at a mutual understanding. It provides an opportunity to exchange and share gifts that can be of mutual benefits.

Interfaith Dialogue aims at bringing followers of different religions and faiths at a round table to discuss issues of common social interests. It is a voluntary act aiming to achieve peaceful coexistence among people of different faiths. Build a culture of collaboration and interaction as equal human beings.

The term *Interfaith Dialogue* to some it means the same as *Interreligious dialogue*. However some want to differentiate between the two terms, " *interreligious* and *interfaith*". To me religion is an outward identity of a community who follow certain "subjective" belief based on teaching and traditions handed over.

**Faith** is what holds a religious community together; it is a *subjective power*. Faith is expressed through actions and testimony or statements. Every religious community has a foundation of belief that produces faith towards what religions teach and claim.

Interreligious /interfaith dialogue refers to constructive and positive voluntary cooperation among people of different religions at institutional levels. It can be at Global, Regional, and National or at grassroots levels for the same purpose of fostering peace and peaceful coexistence among people of faith. *Constructive dialogue* can also be between different religious traditions within the same faith. This is true with Christianity and Islam religions, where we find a number of "sects or denominations/groups, who have same basic beliefs, but differ in interpretation and traditions. This is why we should also engage in Ecumenical discourse or intra-faith dialogue.

Our global context is changing; we are becoming a family in a shrinking globe, people of different cultures and ideology meet and live in the neighborhood. Therefore there is no way one can deny the other. We need to seriously engage religious communities in constructive interfaith dialogue. To achieve human development we need sustainable peace, justice, freedom of belief and expression and sanctity of life.

We are all aware that a number of religions have some notable differences. These differences have caused *artificial walls* that differentiates one group from the other.

*Interfaith dialogue* and *intra-faith dialogue* is key to religious harmony and peace. Let us invest on it. We may not agree on a number of religious issues; but this should not warrant any one to hate the other, cause violence and discrimination. Religious differences and should not render us into pieces but bring us as a people and a harmonious family of God the Creator and the Savior.

Interreligious/interfaith relation is not *syncretism*, because we are not trying to form a one *compound* religion; rather understand the other and respect our religious differences.

Interreligious dialogue is neither *daa'wa* nor *evangelism*, where one tries to share religious teaching in order to convert the other. It is not an agreement among religions/faiths to let go their long cherished doctrines, traditions and beliefs to form one religion as many doubt today. But it is a genuine struggle to make religions the source of peace and harmony, and not the cause of atrocities, violence, war and genocide in our mother earth.

## **HUMAN MIGRATION IN THE TWENTYFIRST CENTURY A RESON FOR INTERCULTURE AND INTERFAITH DIALOGUE**

Twenty First Century has seen millions of people migrating from one nation to another nation, from one continent to another continent. Different reasons have forced people to migrate to other countries to find new settlement. They move to new cultures, while they migrate with their own cultures. It is a factual statement to say that we are in an era where geographical and political boundaries are no longer closed but open wide to welcome the other. In this situation dialogue is crucial to avoid *identity crisis*, between the host citizens and the migrants.

We need to help citizens of European countries who have no choice but to receive migrants from war tone nations in Middle East and Arabia, from Poverty stricken Sub-Saharan countries who migrate with their cultures in heart. Migrants are human beings who run away to find safety, peace and life. On the other hand, Citizens of the host nations have strived to maintain and strengthen justice, rule of law and harmony.

In order for both of them attain their desires of peaceful living, there should be an attitude of give and take and sometime as a necessity for peaceful coexistence be ready to give away as a sacrifice of love. This is achievable when communities engage in constructive and sustainable dialogue; both interfaith and intercultural dialogue. People who sit to talk will build understanding and trust..

## **DIALOGUE IS NOT NEW**

Since time memorial, People have tried hard to understand one another for peaceful coexistence and harmony. In the 20<sup>th</sup> Century more planned efforts between Abrahamic religions began and continued to hold dialogs for conflict prevention and peace building, although there were so many huddles.

Today in Sub Saharan Africa it is a common phenomenon to see people of different religions and faiths engage in a daily dialogue when they take part in social economic activities without religious or ideological prejudice; such as in funerals, weddings, national activities, acts of help and rescue in times of disasters, etc. Religious respect, acceptance and trust is a reality. Several interfaith platforms have been operating.

For example, from 1957, African Christian religious leaders came together to discuss on the future of Independent Africa. These were the years when colonial Africa began to achieve independence from colonialists, who divided Africans into tribal lines and mostly in religious lines, Christians and

Muslims. The question was, how will independent Africa be when the colonialists go, will African remain divided on religious lines? They agreed to come up with an interfaith program between Christians and Muslims. This platform was called "Christian Muslim Relation in Africa PROCMURA. Muslim and Christian leaders representing their communities set at round table as one people with different faiths, but people of one continent and nations. PROCUMURA strived to build understanding, sharing and stretching a hand of friendship to build a peaceful just and harmonious community.

At a continental level we have a platform for dialogue known as, African Council for Religious Leaders (ACRL). It is a platform for all Religions in quest to mobilize religious leaders and their communities to build peaceful, just, hopeful, and harmonious societies in Africa.

With the same motif, in Tanzania top religious leaders of nine institutionalized religious organizations have signed a Memorandum of Understanding to cooperate in peace building conflict prevention through constructive dialogue. This platform is known as Interreligious Council for Peace Tanzania (IRCPT) of which I am the Executive Director. When we meet we greet each other:

**"Love and Peace; different religions// Different religions; Love and Peace"**

Love and quest for peace call us all to collaborate in peace building conflict prevention and building national unity. This is what we can regard as *practical dialogue*. This has been lived for decades.

## **WHY INTERFAITH DIALOGUE IS IMPORTANT TODAY**

Faith is subjective, it involves the heart. Man has a gift of free will to choice and belief. Therefore different thought and ideology cannot be avoided, but understood and guided. By the end of 21<sup>st</sup> century, there arose a new phenomenon; we have witnessed serious acts of discrimination and hatred on line of religion and faith, violent extremism causing mistrust, misconceptions, fear, and a state of insecurity. In response to this negative attitude; peace loving people have tirelessly devoted in bringing different religions to a round table; through religious leaders and scholars for constructive dialogue, to foster understanding and peaceful coexistence. This is a very effective infrastructure for conflict prevention and for building sustainable peace. It is a true saying that "We can try to change things or make some things disappear, but we cannot make any religious community to be whipped away". Religious communities need accept one another and indulge in dialogue, tirelessly for achieving peace and human dignity. Religion is what makes societies find their purpose and identity. Religion instructs, teach of how relate with other people; connects the faithful together as a believing family, and connects them to the creator.

Religious communities are like a beautiful farm of flowers with different colors, odors, and shapes but all regardless of their biological differences, share the same ground and soil, draw life from the same sun, and waters.

We people of the world although we have same life beginnings and same end have different ideologies, faiths, religions, cultures and colors. Like a beautiful garden of GOD WITH

DIFFERENT COLORS ought to live as a larger family on this Earth, and in our different because all humanity have the same basic human needs the world provides.

It shocks me when I hear or read and see discriminative speeches and acts on line of religious affiliation, ideology, ethnicity, gender and color, which some have led to violence, war, atrocities, genocide and many injustice.

People who do not believe in any religion blame religious communities for being the cause of atrocities and suffering of innocent people. No one can justify killing someone in the name of religion unless that religion does not originate from the Almighty God, the creator, the all-knowing, all powerful and eternal. It does not enter into my mind when religious people who claim to represent God for the wellbeing of humanity, plan and execute killings, destroying God's creation, killing innocent people; women and children, in the name of religion. Such people do not value dialogue and are against human sanctity. We must make all efforts to bring them at dialogue table for them to speak out their demands and fears. Constructive dialogue and not force or discriminating them.

We should never allow this evil to hold foot in our world we know something is wrong that is the reason we are gathered here to discuss and come up with concrete resolutions, plan of action.

We need to work hard to give religion its rightful duty to make this generation and generations to come a loving and a generous generation, doing good for the glory of the Creator.

Constructive dialogue is necessary for peace building and religious cooperation; I applaud such efforts to bring people of nations to share experiences, knowledge and strategies in achieving peace in our multi religious, and multi culture world.

We may also need to conduct theological constructive dialogue where specialists and theologians from different faiths will discuss on theological themes agreed and those which can add impetus to building understanding among religions. Constructive dialogue such as this one aims at building bridges between religions, to cooperate and maintain peace and prevent violence and discrimination. Such interfaith dialogue forms a major source in the study of religions and peace building.

## **CRITICISM OF INTERFAITH DIALOGUE**

These efforts have been criticized by followers of different religions thinking that leaders are trying to betray them by sitting together with people of other religions. To them every religion should remain within its walls; in a closed but pursue to convert every person who is not a believer. Here is where religious scholars and religious leaders need to invest their time and leadership. Our global context requires religions to teach extensively on interreligious dialogue and freedom of each person to believe any religion he chooses. As nations of the globe opens doors to welcome

people of different nations, cultures and faiths, same should be to religious communities. They should allow those who believe another faith without condemning them as traitors.

Believers ought to know the basic aim of interfaith dialogue, to champion on welcoming the other instead of prevention of discriminating people of other faiths. Build a spirit of acceptance, stand against prejudices, and conflicts which distorts peace and peaceful coexistence.

Some are worried that dialogue will discourage evangelism, and daa'wa which is central to every faith. Such people have a genuine fear, however in a world where we want freedom, justice, and peaceful coexistence, constructive dialogue is very important and worthy to engage to. Some peace makers and giants of interreligious dialogue have suffered reproach threats and have been harmed. These are faithful to their faith they are not traitors or backslider, but understand the fundamentals that can make religion flourish and reach people with its divine message. Not hate nor intimidation or discrimination; but respect, truth, love, respect and free will of an individual.

It is a peaceful and harmonious context where people can sit and follow the teachings. Without peace nothing is achieved, religion is for people, and people need peace of mind to follow the religious teachings, then if someone thinks that he/she can use force and violence to make people follow religion, he/she is a destroyer of that faith. In order for a faith or a religion to excel, it should accept challenges, and purification through the reality in the societies.

If a religion or faith is not challenged, I mean, believers do not interact with people of other religions or faiths; the faith of believers cannot grow to strength. It is like someone who went to college attained his degree but he cannot face challenges from other scholars to share his knowledge and learn from others. I believe this conference will help each of us to self-examine if his faith has made an impact to the peace and love in our societies.

## UNDERSTANDING THE PRINCIPLES OF DIALOGUE FOR PEACE IN CHRISTIANITY

When Jesus was born in Bethlehem Angels sang a song of Peace to all people on Earth. Luk.2:11-14. "This will be a sign to you. You will find a baby rapped in cloths and lying in a manger" Suddenly a great company of heavenly hosts appeared with the angel, praising God saying, "*Glory to God in the highest, and on earth **peace** to men on whom his favor rests*" In the Book of Hebrews 7:2 Jesus is presented as the King of Salem King of peace. He is Prince of Peace who call his believers to earnestly seek to have peace with ALL people and the righteousness that no one will see God if he/she does not have it. Hebr.12:14

The word Peace appears 400 times in whole bible. Jesus as the Prince of Peace, he came that humanity will have **peace** with God and **peace** between one another. The Hebrew word **Shalom** is translated to mean joy, assurance, protection, justice dignity, and hope; It is peace in its totality.

Sustainable and true peace begins and ends with God. If people have peace with God they will have peace within themselves and would love to maintain and share that peace with their neighbors.

Peace is a culmination (outcome) of several things. These are, Justice, dignity, acceptance, freedom, and security (of provisions and protection). The Bible admonishes us to make sure that

our obedience, our love and true worship to God is accomplished through doing things that give peace to people. Since God is love; and true love comes from God, the world and people must come to God who is the source of love. Christianity teaches that love is paramount for righteousness, in 1Cor.13:1-13 we are to love because love is patient, it is kind, love does not envy, it does not boast, it isn't proud neither rude. Love is not self-seeking, it is not easily angered, and it keeps no record of wrongs. Love does not delight in evil but rejoices with the truth. It always protects, always trusts, always hopes, and always perseveres. LOVE never fails.

The true color of Christianity is PEACE as a product of Love of God manifested in His Son Jesus Christ, the Prince of Peace, who pronounced forgiveness to sinners and those who persecuted him. Jesus taught us to love God and to love our neighbors as ourselves. Such vertical and horizontal love will never allow violence but always will pursue understanding, forgiveness and reconciliation. When we face differences we are not to turn into violence but dialogue to find solution and live in harmony and forgiveness

Jesus not only taught a nonviolence gospel, He demonstrated it in his entire life. In (Mathew 5:5-10) Jesus taught believers how their attitude and hearts should be. We know that, "Blessed are the meek, for they will inherit the earth", (a meek person is not violent. Such people will always be honored by their societies). Blessed are those who hunger and thirsty for righteousness for they will be filled, blessed are the merciful for they will be shown mercy, blessed are the pure in heart for they will see God. (**Pure heart does not harbors grudges, hate or revenge**),

***Blessed are the peace makers for they will be called sons of God"*** True disciple of Jesus Christ is required by God to live a nonviolence life. We are to make every effort to ***"live in peace with all men and to be holy, the holiness that man will not see God if he does not have it"*** Hebrew 12:14

Jesus was tempted by Pharisees and the Jews so that he could react violently to prove him guilty, as they falsely accused him. His disciples having witnessed his authority and divine powers they tried to make him use his divine power, an act which could be regarded as a violent act. He instead kept silent and concluded his passion by pronouncing forgiveness to all those who were persecuting him and those accused him falsely.

The question today is why those who identify themselves with Jesus Christ do not make peace a priority. Claim to be Christians and yet are always violent and perpetuates acts of violence! The truth of the matter is, they have not accepted the prince of peace to be lord of their hearts, instead have religion called Christianity. There is one problem to religious people, that they propagate religion to belong to God, and that God is "all knowing", powerful, omniscience, omnipotent and omnipresent, a highest power, and yet they robe God his position. They can kill, destroy and cause violence, in the name of God and protecting religion. Do we need to kill people who God created! Why should someone decide to destroy something he has not created! God the loving creator sent and continues to call men and women such as us here present to call sinners to repentance and worship him, God is in the business of saving and recreating hearts, he wants to save and give life so that at judgment day each person will have no excuse. I think this is where dialogue should help us not to go overboard when we practice religion. Violence has nothing to do

with God and religion. Whenever Jesus met his disciples he greeted them, ***shalom*** even after resurrection before ascension to heaven he greeted them, "Peace be with you"

Christianity unveils the God of Peace; he created the world and the universe out of chaos, he brought everything into harmony, it is sin, rebellion that brought chaos and violent spirit to mankind. God who is Love and source of peace sent the Prince of peace to this chaotic world to bring peace. His life and teaching was to reconcile the fallen humanity with God and bring a spirit of forgiveness, love and justice.

## **WORKING CAPACITY OF RELIGIONS IN PROMOTING PEACE AND COEXISTENCE**

Religions and religious leaders and scholars at all levels have capacity to promote peace and coexistence. Globally, religions as institutions and faiths, holds over 85-95 percent of the world's population. These religions have leaders and scholars who are trusted respected and taken as models. They speak to the hearts of believers, and in many traditions they are not questioned of what they speak, the faithful believe that when they speak, God has spoken through them. With such respect and opportunity to meet people every day and speak to their hearts, religious leaders are a very important force to maintaining peace building and bring peace where there is no peace.

If given capacity and agree to come together at a round table for constructive dialogue to build peace and peaceful coexistence, the world will be healed and sustainable peace will be realized.

One thing to bear in mind is that if religions and religious leaders fail to see this noble call and taking in mind the number of religions and followers populating the world, any misunderstanding between religions will result to unending violence, wars, and genocide. Religious wars never end and are destructive. Religious leaders need to respect this position and take lead in peace building. They can urge people to enjoy peace and peaceful coexistence as people who believe God the creator here on earth and as a rehearsal for life everlasting, where God will rule his people with love and peace.

Once Dr. William Vendley of *Religions for Peace International* said, "In considering whether and how religious leaders can contribute positively to peaceful dialogue, we should first clarify what kind of leadership we're talking about. Religious leaders function in three categories –

1. The official, institutionalized leadership such as Rabbis, Imams, Bishops, Priests Theologians, and so on. Sometimes, their authority is bolstered by a hierarchical church structure or a Chief Rabbinate.
2. Grass-roots lay leadership within religious communities.
3. The other important but often left in interreligious dialogue are the Professional and lay leadership within the various non-governmental organizations, and other frameworks for dialogue and coexistence".

As religious leaders we need to understand that each group has particular assets and liabilities that it brings to the dialogue. In the case of the first group, at least in some religions, they tend to all be men, typically representing the more conservative forces within their religious groups. Their presence generally confers an air of legitimacy to the endeavor of dialogue, but often they have



vested interests in the status quo, or, at least, find it difficult to think "outside the box," something that is essential if progress is to be made.

The other groups may be more inclusive but are sometimes marginalized within their own religions. They may be challenged by the question, "So, who do you actually represent?" They rarely make the headlines. Their dialogue affects them as participants and, perhaps, other members of their families and communities, but it usually lacks wider influence. Those involved in dialogue often experience a "disconnect" between what they and what the decision makers are doing.

Ideally, all three types of leaders should be involved in the process.

## **RELIGIOUS DIALOGUE IS KEY TO PREVENTING VIOLENCE AND EXTREMISM**

Men are violent possessive and selfish by nature, the Bible speaks of this problem when it says, "The heart is deceitful above all things and beyond cure who will understand it?" Jer.17:9 Religious leaders are called and commissioned to speak to the corrupt heart of men. God has given leaders grace and ability to expound the word of Holy God to change the hearts of people to seek peace, love and good neighborliness. At this age of science and technology, Colleges that prepare religious leaders must take seriously the question of peace building, and peaceful coexistence. Failure to equip leaders with knowledge that foster peace BUILDING THROUGH DIALOGUE will result to having religious leaders who are centric minded, discriminatory and who preach to plant separation intolerance and mistrust.

Religions especially the Abrahamic faiths are mandated to witness to "unbelievers" to come to the faith. This cannot be stopped or compromised, the question is "How" we present our message or do evangelism and do daa'wa. The **how** and **what** is very important in witnessing our religions in our multi religious, multi culture world. From 1980s to 2013 we have experienced a rise of groups of people claiming to come from both faiths, popularly known as *Mihadhara* causing religious tensions, mistrust and hate. Thank God that people of our nation had a culture of respect, dialogue and brotherhood; where everyone is a brother or a sister; one family in a nation regardless of religious differences. Our unique socialism known as Ujamaa Ideology. This embodied Ujamaa culture could not be shaken but diffuse the new and imported phenomenon. Dialogue is crucial to peace and harmony, therefore, we must engage everyone.

We in Tanzania have a platform for dialogue and interfaith relation. We have officially established a national platform called, Interreligious Council for peace Tanzania IRCPT (Nov.2016) where top religious leaders of umbrella Faith Based Organization form the Council of religious leaders. Such structures are being established at regional, district, sub district levels, down to society levels. We call them Interfaith Councils. We also continue to establish Women and Youth of faith interfaith networks from national level down to village levels.

Several steps can be taken by religious leaders to strengthen religious dialogue for peace and peaceful coexistence.

- To include the subject of peace and interfaith relation through constructive dialogue
- Conduct regular constructive dialogue at all levels,

- Involve youth in schools, colleges and Universities to undertake constructive dialogue on religious cooperation and peaceful coexistence,
- Bring religious youth groups to participate in various activities to build friendship and trust, share their gifts and achievement, translate their scripture teachings into everyday life, find their commonalities and understand their religious differences, respect them but holding to those shared by all religions,
- Establish National forum /Council for Peace building an organ that brings religious leaders in a round table to discuss issues of national interests. Establish; Interfaith Committees and Women and Youth Interfaith Networks at different levels of the society as an early warning mechanism, peace infrastructures.
- Through these Committees/councils conduct trainings to build capacity of religious leaders on interfaith issues, conflict prevention, reconciliation and conflict transformation.

### **A MODEL OF PEACE AND COEXISTENCE AMONG RELIGIONS**

We can share different models of Peace and coexistence among religions, but these models will vary from country to country depending on the demographic and religious composition. We have countries where there is one religion with majority citizens, and one or two religions with minority of citizens. In other countries there are many religions with one or two religions followed by majority of citizens. There are a number of countries where there is an official religion or faith where a religion takes the leadership of all affairs of the nation.

Let me take Tanzanian model; Tanzania is a nation of over one hundred and twenty tribes and six institutionalized religions with over thirty denominations/sects. Christianity and Islam count the majority of the citizens, scattered all over Tanzania. It is true that in some places of our country one might either find Muslims or Christians to be the majority, but this does not affect religious relations and interaction; people coexist as a nation respecting each other without religious prejudice. Many families have both Christians and Muslims; this is one advantage to our efforts to strengthen religious acceptance, tolerance and peaceful coexistence. Christianity and Islam have lived as neighbors for many years sharing joy and grief, working together in various social economic activities as citizens. Peace building, respect and coexistence is born and nursed in and from the heart; it must be taught and shared. Our religious books have scriptures that teach goodness, love and fear of God. Such teaching ought to be taught to believers from the early years of religious studies, so as to make it the culture of the people.

### **CONCLUSION**

To conclude my paper, I call upon religious leaders to always be true and committed to build peace through constructive dialogue and coexistence. We live in one world, let us live together in peace and not in pieces. God created us all with same human needs, though with different skin colours ethnicity gender and languages. Our origin and our end is the same. Let us make earth a peaceful place to live and worship our Creator God. Keep the world safe and honor life.

Thank you for listening.

**Rev Canon Thomas Godda Muyya**

Contacts: Interreligious Council for Peace Tanzania

a